

A celebrity bartender is shot dead by a politician's son in Shanghvi's new novel inhabited by beautiful people

Sex and the City

By Sam Miller

Siddharth Dhanvant Shanghvi's exuberantly ambitious second novel is set in the recent past, and it begins as a portrayal of the interlinked lives of four beautiful people living in a city he emphatically calls Bombay. Karan is a press photographer who is new to the city, Samar is a gay pianist who has stopped performing, Zaira is a successful film actress, and Rhea is a slightly older married woman who becomes Karan's lover. Each of them is portrayed sympathetically, as a person of honour and talent, sucked into a series of unfortunate events over which they have little control. By the end of part one, Zaira is dead, shot by the son of a politician while working as a celebrity bartender. The tragic story of Jessica Lal, the model shot dead in Delhi in very similar circumstances

in 1999, has been airlifted to Bombay. The focus of this cleverly-constructed novel then widens, as a trial gets underway, a host of rather unpleasant minor characters appear—and the lives of our three surviving heroes begin to crumble.

The author has strong political views, which he makes little attempt to conceal. He has one of his minor characters declare early in the book, that "Mumbai is about as appealing a name for a city as Gonorrhoea." He then ridicules a female politician who insists on calling the city Mumbai, by referring to her "crusty librarian's voice, one that could only be relieved with a dildo". Politicians and socialites are torn apart by Shanghvi's relentless *bon mots*. Like a Dorothy Parker with Tourette's, Shanghvi's wit is exhaustingly dazzling, and more than a little provocative. On the third page, we learn that "glee dripped out of Natasha like precum". Am I the only reader



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